58.3 per cent in 2012, in Karnataka from 88.0 per cent in 2009 to 89.1 per cent in 2012, in Kerala it has increased from 91.9 percent in 2009 to 94.4 percent in 2012 and in Odisha from 74.1 per cent in 2009 to 77.5 per cent in 2012.

More than half of all Std 2 and Std 4 classes sit together with another class: Nationally, in rural government primary schools, students who sit in multi-grade classrooms is rising.

Higher and Technical Education

With the intention of allocating higher amount of funds for primary and secondary education, the central government did put the higher education in the non-priority sector in the era of economic reforms.[4] Though the governmental committment for the development of the sector has not diminished and has taken a new and practical orientation, in future the private sector resources will be harnessed for its proper development.[5] An important challenge in the higher education sector is to bring about reforms not only in the institutions of higher learning but also in the regulatory structures of the higher education system. There are also the challenges of maintaining quality and excellence while ensuring rapid expansion and attracting and retaining good faculty in adequate numbers to meet the demands of the rapidly expanding sector.

The higher education system of India is one of the largest in the world in terms of the number of colleges and universities. While at the time of Independence, there were only 20 universities and 500 colleges with 0.1 million students, their number has increased to ***690*** universities and university-level institutions and 35,539 colleges – of the 690 universities, 44 are central universities, 306 state universities, 145 state private universities, 130 deemed universities, 60 institutes of national importance plus other institutes, and 5 institutions established under State Legislature Acts, as per the latest *Economic Survey 2012-13*.

A number of initiatives[6] have been taken during the *Eleventh Plan* period with focus on improvement of access along with equity and excellence, adoption of state-specific strategies, enhancing the relevance of higher education through curriculum reforms, vocationalization, networking, and